

Weekly Writing - Week 1

Evan Rothwell

29 August, 2025

1. Which do you prefer, coding with ChatGPT and focusing more on theory or learning to code traditional way to understand it better?

I find AI to be fascinating. There are many uses for it today day in age, which can be both good and bad. When I arrived as a freshman in 2022 AI was nonexistent to the global population. My first semester I remember taking CSE102 and it was one of the hardest classes I ever took.

This class consisted of 3 projects each worth about 30% of your grade. I remember completing the first 2 projects and got fine grades, however the 3rd project is where my trouble came. This particular project I spent over 8 hours banging my head trying to complete and pass the test cases. I finally had passed to about 75% completion, and then went back in my code to edit some lines I believed had prevented it from executing fully. In doing so I messed up the syntax somehow, but I did not know this was my problem. After countless hours of searching and meeting with my TA I still was unable to find the specific issue. This single error dropped me to about 30% completion on the assignment which tanked my grade for the class and my GPA, which contributed to being denied admission to Broad when I applied the next semester.

Fast forward to my next coding class PLS202. I was now a junior and AI had become prevalent in the world. This class allowed the same AI usage rules that are used in this class. I had a similar experience with error codes and syntax, but this time I copied my code and the error into ChatGPT and it gave me the specific line and told me exactly what was wrong. I was able to ask it follow up questions to better understand what was going on and was able to complete my assignment on time.

This experience has made me love AI, however I also can see how it can be troublesome. I like the current situation of learning how to code but being able to use AI if you are stuck. I believe people have a choice if they really want to learn it they will, and if they want to go into the real world not knowing it is their fault. However, I do think that is not going to be that much of an issue now because they can just go into AI and figure out how to sort the data and manipulate it in 10 seconds. That makes me consider the question of if learning it is needed at all, which I believe as of now it is. I think that a class like this introducing the basics is necessary to understand what is going on, and having the knowledge to prove to people in the workforce is necessary. I think this question should be addressed in the future as AI is implemented further into society.